

Writer OS Minimal Design System Style Guide

Version: 0.1 Source prototype: [writer-os-ui-minimal.html](#) Primary direction: severe editorial minimalism for a serious writing instrument

1. Design Thesis

Writer OS should feel like a composed editorial instrument, not a productivity dashboard, AI chat surface, or decorative notebook app.

The interface should be:

- **Severe, quiet, almost invisible.** The design gets its personality through restraint.
- **Reading-first.** The primary unit is a composed page of thought, not a card, feed, chat bubble, or widget.
- **Editorial, not cozy.** Use literary typography, hairline rules, and measured spacing rather than faux paper, handwriting, or nostalgic texture.
- **AI-invisible.** The intelligence is implied by prioritization: what is shown, hidden, sequenced, and named.
- **Almost static.** Motion should feel like a page settling, not a product performing.

Anti-Patterns

Do not make Writer OS feel like:

- AI SaaS: glowing gradients, purple/blue sheen, assistant avatars, chat-first composition.
 - A project dashboard: KPIs, widget grids, dense management panels, task-board aesthetics.
 - A precious journal: faux handwriting, torn paper, stickers, heavy textures, sentimental notebook cues.
 - A generic mobile app: rounded card stacks, pill-heavy controls, overly familiar startup UI.
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2. Visual Language

Core Metaphor

The app is a **quiet editorial page** with a narrow margin system. It should feel closer to a carefully typeset essay draft than a workspace dashboard.

Primary Surfaces

Use:

- pages
- hairline rules
- measured rows
- excerpts
- small state dots
- document-weather strips
- narrow margin labels

Avoid:

- stacked cards
- floating panels
- chat bubbles
- heavy controls
- decorative frames

Layout Personality

The layout should preserve meaningful blank space. Silence is part of the interface.

Use asymmetry lightly:

- a narrow left margin rail
- vertical page mark
- one dominant content measure

- large type only for true page-level ideas

3. Design Tokens

These tokens are the current canonical palette from the prototype.

```
:root {
  --ground: #fbfaf6;
  --page: #ffffffb;
  --page-muted: #f4f1e8;

  --ink: #171512;
  --ink-2: #49443b;
  --ink-3: #858072;

  --hairline: #d9d3c5;
  --hairline-2: #ece7db;

  --active: #7d3b25;
  --ready: #50684e;
  --source: #3c6672;
  --open: #9a741c;

  --shadow: rgba(42, 34, 22, 0.08);

  --serif: "Iowan Old Style", "Palatino Linotype", "Book Antiqua", Georgia, serif;
  --mono: "SF Mono", "IBM Plex Mono", "JetBrains Mono", Menlo, monospace;
}
```

Night Mode Tokens

```
:root[data-tone="night"] {
  --ground: #11110f;
  --page: #191916;
  --page-muted: #202018;

  --ink: #f3ecdc;
  --ink-2: #cfc4ac;
  --ink-3: #8f856f;

  --hairline: #454131;
  --hairline-2: #2d2b22;

  --active: #cc8063;
  --ready: #aab894;
  --source: #9bbbc2;
  --open: #d0ab4a;

  --shadow: rgba(0, 0, 0, 0.24);
}
```

Color Semantics

Use color sparingly. Color should never decorate; it should clarify state.

TOKEN	MEANING	USAGE
`--active`	Current work / primary focus	active item dot, active label, urgent but non-alarming state
`--ready`	Settled / reviewed / safe to proceed	completed state, next-ready indicator
`--source`	Source / reference material	citations, excerpts, raw material markers
`--open`	Unresolved question / tension	live question, uncertainty, conceptual pressure
`--ink-3`	Quiet metadata	dates, labels, inactive navigation

4. Typography

Typography is the main design material.

Font Roles

- **Serif:** prose, page titles, prompts, article excerpts.
- **Mono:** metadata, navigation, state labels, timestamps, indexes.

Type Scale

Recommended mobile scale:

ROLE	SIZE	LINE HEIGHT	WEIGHT	NOTES
Page title	43-48px	0.92	500	Use for screen-level concepts only
Section heading	28px	1.03	500	Article/source section headings
Row title	19px	1.12	500	Quiet list items
Primary question	25-26px	1.17	400	One per Today page
Body	16px	1.45	400	Main reading text
Supporting body	14.5px	1.35-1.45	400	Row descriptions
Metadata	9-10px	1.0-1.55	700-800	Mono, uppercase, tracked

Typography Rules

- Do not use negative letter spacing.
 - Do not scale font size fluidly with viewport width inside the mobile app surface.
 - Keep metadata uppercase and tracked, but short.
 - Avoid overusing bold; hierarchy should come from scale, rule weight, and placement.
 - Treat large type as expensive. If everything is large, nothing is quiet.
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5. Spacing And Layout

Mobile Shell

The mobile surface uses:

- narrow left rail: 54–70px
- content measure: approximately 290px
- bottom navigation: 72px
- top chrome: 42px

Current prototype values:

```
.view {  
  padding: 20px 26px 26px 70px;  
}  
  
.measure {  
  max-width: 290px;  
}
```

Spacing Scale

Use this practical scale:

TOKEN	VALUE	USE
`space-1`	5px	tight label/title relationships
`space-2`	10px	metadata group spacing
`space-3`	15-16px	row padding
`space-4`	18-20px	section rhythm
`space-5`	26-28px	primary blocks
`space-6`	32-38px	major screen separation
`space-7`	44px+	desktop board sections

Rule Weights

- Use `1px` rules almost everywhere.
- Use `var(--ink)` rule color only for major conceptual boundaries.
- Use `var(--hairline)` for normal separation.
- Use `var(--hairline-2)` for subtle nav and background rail lines.

6. State Grammar

Writer OS state should feel annotated, not badged.

State Dot

Use a small dot to indicate state in lists.

```
.quiet-row::before {  
  width: 6px;  
  height: 6px;  
  border-radius: 50%;  
}
```

State color mapping:

- active: rust
- ready: green
- source: blue
- open: amber
- inactive: quiet gray

State Label

Use mono uppercase labels:

```
.state {  
  font-family: var(--mono);  
  font-size: 9px;  
  font-weight: 800;  
  letter-spacing: 0.12em;  
  text-transform: uppercase;  
}
```

Labels should be short:

- Active
- Ready
- Source
- Open
- Captured
- Question
- Next

Avoid:

- Needs immediate action
- High priority
- AI recommended
- Task status pending

7. Core Components

Today Page

Purpose: orient the writer without turning the session into management.

Required elements:

- date lockup
- **Walk / Desk** mode switch
- page title
- one primary question or desk index
- three or fewer quiet signals

Walk mode:

- one question
- very low density
- no source queue
- no operational controls beyond navigation

Desk mode:

- short ordered work index
- still text-first
- no dashboard widgets

Primary Question

Use for the one live thought that should carry a walk.

Rules:

- one per screen
- serif

- 25-26px on mobile
- bounded by top and bottom ink rules
- no icon
- no assistant attribution

Quiet Row

Use for active signals, blockers, next work, and brief article/source state.

Structure:

- state dot
- state label
- row title
- one-sentence explanation

Do not add buttons inside quiet rows unless there is a clear user action.

Work Index

Used in Desk mode for ordered work.

Structure:

- number
- sentence-length work item
- short state mark

The work index is not a task list. It is a reading order.

Document Weather

Used to summarize article/source condition without creating a dashboard.

Example dimensions:

- Draft
- Voice
- Lineage

- Risk

Each weather cell should be terse: one label, one short value.

Source Note

Used for source excerpts and raw material.

Structure:

- source label
- excerpt as serif quote
- one short contextual note

Raw material should feel like cited marginalia, not an inbox.

System Page

Purpose: expose design/operating rules without leaving the app language.

Use it for:

- rules of restraint
 - token/type examples
 - state examples
 - implementation notes
-

8. Navigation

Navigation is a bottom text rail.

Current nav:

- Today
- Walk
- Close

- Article
- Source
- System

Rules:

- mono uppercase
- six items maximum
- equal-width tabs
- active tab uses muted page fill, not a loud color
- no icons unless usability testing proves text-only is failing

Avoid:

- floating action buttons
- large bottom sheets
- icon-only controls
- colorful selected states

9. Motion

Motion principle: **a page settles. Nothing performs.**

Allowed:

- view opacity fade: `~220ms`
- slight vertical settle: `translateY(8px)` to `0`
- no bounce
- no spring
- no animated gradients

Current transition:

```
.view {  
  opacity: 0;  
  transform: translateY(8px);  
  transition: opacity 220ms ease, transform 260ms ease;  
}
```

Use motion only to preserve orientation. Never use motion as delight for its own sake.

10. Screen Patterns

Walk Screen

The Walk screen should be the calmest surface.

It should include:

- timer
- one captured thought
- one minimal capture control

It should not include:

- transcript feed
- assistant replies
- source lists
- multi-step prompts
- dense controls

Close Screen

The Close screen should feel like filing, not finishing.

It should include:

- captured note

- open question
- next page / next action

Language should avoid false completion. Good words:

- filed
- captured
- next
- open
- return

Avoid:

- completed
- resolved
- done
- optimized

Article Screen

The Article screen should remain prose-led.

Use:

- article title
- lede
- document weather
- outline beats

Avoid:

- kanban stages
- progress percentages
- revision score
- AI critique panel

Source Screen

The Source screen treats raw material as excerpts.

Use:

- source codes
- blockquotes
- short contextual notes

Avoid:

- generic file list
 - upload/inbox UI
 - checkboxes
 - bulk management controls
-

11. Accessibility And Usability

Contrast

Text should meet WCAG AA contrast in both light and night modes.

Special attention:

- `--ink-3` metadata is intentionally quiet; do not use it for essential body copy.
- state colors should never be the only indicator; pair color with text labels.

Touch Targets

- Navigation tabs: minimum height `72px`.
- Mode buttons: minimum height `42px`.
- Avoid tiny icon-only controls.

Text Fit

- Do not truncate primary questions.

- Do not force one-line labels if they need space.
- Keep nav labels short.
- Keep source and state labels compact.

Reduced Motion

If implementing in production, respect `prefers-reduced-motion`:

```
@media (prefers-reduced-motion: reduce) {  
  * {  
    animation-duration: 0.01ms !important;  
    animation-iteration-count: 1 !important;  
    scroll-behavior: auto !important;  
    transition-duration: 0.01ms !important;  
  }  
}
```

12. Implementation Notes

Recommended Structure

Treat the design system as a small token/component layer:

- tokens: color, type, spacing, rule weights
- primitives: page, rail, rule, state label, state dot
- components: today page, quiet row, work index, document weather, source note
- screen compositions: Today, Walk, Close, Article, Source, System

Component Naming

Suggested names:

- `PageShell`
- `PageRail`

- PageMark
- BottomNav
- ModeSwitch
- PrimaryQuestion
- QuietRow
- WorkIndex
- DocumentWeather
- SourceNote
- FiledNote
- SystemSpecRow

State Names

Use semantic state names in code:

```
type WriterState = "active" | "ready" | "source" | "open" | "inactive";
```

Do not name states by color.

Content Constraints

The design depends on disciplined copy.

Recommended limits:

- primary question: 1 sentence
 - quiet row title: 3-7 words
 - quiet row body: 1 sentence
 - weather value: 1-2 words
 - source note context: 1 sentence
-

13. Acceptance Checklist

Before shipping a screen, verify:

- The screen can be understood in under five seconds.
 - The page has one dominant thought.
 - The UI does not look like chat.
 - The UI does not look like a dashboard.
 - Color is only used for state.
 - Body copy remains readable in light and night modes.
 - State is communicated by text plus color, not color alone.
 - The writer is not asked to manage more than the current surface needs.
 - The screen still works if all decorative cues are removed.
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14. Current Artifacts

- Visual prototype: `writer-os-ui-minimal.html`
- PDF export: `writer-os-ui-minimal.pdf`
- Earlier alternate direction: `writer-os-ui-prototype.html`

Use the minimal HTML prototype as the canonical visual reference. Use the earlier field-notebook prototype only as historical exploration.